

An Equal Music

The book reaches out to a different linguistic world inhabited by the great poet

| By Damayanti Datta |

It was his way of keeping despondency at bay. Besieged by personal tragedies, financial losses and broken health, he sought a light-hearted escape from reality: translating his verses into English, a language he had never learnt formally. It was a journey into the unknown. But cooped up in his roof-top study—looking out over mustard fields and the silvery Padma—poems came in a flurry, till 103 items were reborn as *Gitanjali*. They symbolised a rebirth for the poet, too. Armed with his mid-summer musings, Rabindranath Tagore transfigured himself into a legend, winning the Nobel Prize for literature in 1913.

The long and storied history of Tagore's musical journey comes alive in Reba Som's *Rabindranath Tagore: The Singer and His Song*. Every timeline of songs is silhouetted against his human impulses: memories, desires, dreams, doubts and anxieties. *Gitanjali* forms but a chapter, but you get to know about Tagore's diffidence on his English ("That I cannot write English is such a patent fact that I never had even the vanity to feel ashamed of it"); the trauma at losing the manuscript of translations while negotiating the unfamiliar London tube station (it was fortuitously turned in at the lost-and-found office by an anonymous good samaritan); or the way *Gitanjali* swept the global literary world into a vortex of excitement ("Yeats carried the manuscript with him for days, reading atop omnibuses, on trains, in restaurants, often dodging inquisitive eyes").

But if you are from Bengal, this is just the sort of book you will have seen—if not read—on bookshelves in every genteel household, crammed thick at libraries, displayed proudly at book fairs and discussed threadbare at seminars for years. From E.J. Thompson's first memoirs in 1921, to those by Dhurjati Prasad Mukerji, Buddhadeva Bose, Krishna Kripalani, Amartya Sen, William Radice to E.P. Thompson—the list of Tagore's English biographies is way too long. The anecdotal narratives therefore create a compelling sense of déjà vu. Som has declaredly used music as the leitmotif. But for a poet whose lyrics were poetry first, the boundaries between music and verse are hardly that well-defined. The book begins with a cheery note on Som's personal experience of rediscovering Tagore while in Rome. An accomplished musician, perhaps the CD tucked inside the back cover could have been hers and not of sundry Rabindrasangeet singers? One last word: if you have ever felt the need to reach out to a different linguistic world that relates to Tagore chiefly through *Jana gana mana*, you would appreciate this book. ■



RABINDRANATH TAGORE: THE SINGER AND HIS SONG
by REBA SOM
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 599
Pages: 283

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. Paths of Glory
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
2. The Winner Stands Alone
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
3. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. The Associate
John Grisham, Arrow
5. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

1. Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
2. A Better India A Better World
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
3. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
4. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
5. Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. Of Course I Love You... Till I Find Someone Better
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti
7. Unaccustomed Earth
Jhumpa Lahiri, Random House India
8. My Friend Sancho
Amit Varma, Hachette India

NON-FICTION

6. BPO-Sutra: True Stories from Inside India's BPOs & Call Centres
Sudhindra Mokhasi, Rupa
7. Leadership In The Era of Economic Uncertainty
Ram Charan, TMH
12. Welcome to Advertising! Now Get Lost.
Omkar Sane, Westland

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